

Verbal Analogies

COMPLETE LEARNING GUIDE

What You'll Learn

Analogy questions (A is to B as C is to ?) test whether you can name the **PRECISE** relationship between a pair of words and then find another pair sharing that exact same relationship — not just any loosely related pair. The single most reliable technique is building a short 'bridge sentence' connecting A and B in plain English, then testing each answer option by substituting it into the same bridge sentence with C. This sub-module covers the bridge-sentence technique, a taxonomy of the relationship types that recur most often (synonym, antonym, part-to-whole, cause-effect, degree, tool-to-user, function/classification), reversed-order analogies, double analogies, and the discipline of eliminating options that share the right general category but the wrong direction of relationship.

1. The Bridge-Sentence Technique

Write a short, precise sentence describing how A relates to B, then test each option by substituting it for C and D in the exact same sentence structure — if the sentence still makes logical sense, the option is a strong candidate.

- 'Pen : Write :: Knife : ?' Bridge sentence: 'A pen is a tool used to write.' Applying the same bridge to knife: 'A knife is a tool used to ____.' Answer: 'Cut' — the bridge sentence holds perfectly with this substitution.

2. Relationship Type: Synonym and Antonym Pairs

Some analogies are built purely on the first pair being synonyms or antonyms — the second pair must share the **SAME** type (both synonyms, or both antonyms), not mix the two.

- 'Happy : Joyful :: Sad : ?' (synonym relationship). Answer: 'Sorrowful'. 'Hot : Cold :: Light : ?' (antonym relationship). Answer: 'Dark'.

3. Relationship Type: Part-to-Whole and Function

Part-to-whole analogies pair a component with the larger object it belongs to; function analogies pair a tool or role with its purpose — mixing these up (e.g., picking a part-to-whole option for a function-based first pair) is a common error.

- Part-to-whole: 'Page : Book :: Brick : ?' Answer: 'Wall'. Function: 'Doctor : Hospital :: Teacher : ?' Bridge: 'A doctor's typical workplace is a hospital.' Answer: 'School'.

4. Relationship Type: Cause-Effect and Degree

Cause-effect analogies pair an action/event with its typical result; degree analogies pair two words describing the same quality at different intensities — both require matching not just the category but the exact direction (which word is the cause and which the effect; which word is milder and which more intense).

- Cause-effect: 'Fire : Ash :: Storm : ?' Answer: 'Debris'. Degree: 'Warm : Hot :: Cool : ?' (mild to intense). Answer: 'Cold' (cool is the mild version of cold, just as warm is the mild version of hot).

5. Reversed-Order (Flipped) Analogies

Occasionally the answer options are structured in the REVERSE order of the original pair (D:C instead of C:D) — always verify the direction of the relationship in the options matches the direction established by A:B before selecting.

- 'Bird : Nest :: Bee : ?' Bridge: 'A bird lives in a nest.' If the options include both 'Hive : Bee' and 'Bee : Hive' phrasing, the correct choice must preserve the SAME direction as the original (animal, then dwelling) — 'Hive' alone, matching the 'Bee : Hive' structure, not a reversed 'Hive : Bee' framing.

6. Double Analogies (Two Blanks)

Some questions give only C, leaving both the relationship-type word and the final answer as blanks (A:B :: ?:?) — solve these by first fully defining the A:B relationship, then generating a plausible C:D pair from scratch and checking it against the given options.

- 'Fish : Water :: ? : ?' Bridge: 'A fish lives in water (its natural habitat).' A matching option pair: 'Bird : Air' or 'Bear : Forest' — any option preserving the exact 'lives in its natural habitat' relationship is valid; an option like 'Water : Fish' (reversed direction) is not.

7. Eliminating Right-Category, Wrong-Direction Options

A very common trap option shares the correct general relationship category as A:B but gets the direction or specific role backward — always re-check that the option preserves not just the type of relationship but its exact direction.

- 'Key : Lock :: ?' Bridge: 'A key is used to open a lock.' A trap option 'Door : House' shares the general 'part enables access to whole' flavor loosely but reverses the specific 'tool opens object' direction; the correct match is something like 'Password : Account' (a credential that grants access), preserving the exact tool-to-target direction.

Common Pitfalls

- Picking an option that's loosely related to C in general topic rather than one sharing the EXACT relationship type and direction as A:B.
- Confusing a synonym-based first pair with an antonym-based second pair (or vice versa).
- Mixing up part-to-whole and function/classification relationship types when they superficially look similar.
- Missing the direction of a degree relationship (mild-to-intense vs intense-to-mild) and picking the wrong-direction option.
- Not checking whether the answer options are given in reversed order relative to the original A:B pair.
- In double analogies, generating a plausible C:D pair without first fully and precisely defining the A:B relationship in words.

Key Takeaways

- Always build a precise bridge sentence connecting A and B before evaluating any option.
- Match not just the relationship CATEGORY (synonym, part-whole, cause-effect) but its exact DIRECTION.
- Watch for reversed-order answer options that share the right words but the wrong sequence.
- In double analogies, fully define the A:B relationship in a sentence before searching for a matching C:D pair.
- Eliminate options that are topically related but fail the bridge-sentence substitution test.
- Distinguish between similar-looking relationship types (part-to-whole vs function, cause-effect vs mere association).

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<https://www.indiabix.com/verbal-ability/analogy/>

GeeksforGeeks — Verbal Analogy Questions

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